much more. In the eight years, we had experienced virtually all of life's highs and lows. We had been through it all together, and now it was time to say good-bye. How I wanted to say to each one how deeply Nancy and I appreciated them and how much their work had meant to us. We tried to do some of that as we left the East Room, but when the band started playing "Auld Lang Syne" we couldn't say much of anything.

On January 20, I got up earlier than usual and did some last-minute puttering in my study, then went over to the Oval Office.

Alone in the office, I wrote a note to George Bush and stuck it in the top drawer of the desk that in a few hours would become his. I wrote the note on a little pad of paper with a printed heading: DON'T LET THE TURKEYS GET YOU DOWN. It said:

Dear George

You'll have moments when you want to use this particular stationery. Well, go for it.

George, I treasure the memories we share and wish you all the very best. You'll be in my prayers. God bless you and Barbara. I'll miss our Thursday lunches.

Ron

All the members of my staff had submitted their resignations effective January 19, so I didn't expect anyone else to come into the Oval Office that morning. But Ken Duberstein, who had replaced Howard Baker as my chief of staff, came in at our regular meeting time, and so did my national security advisor, Colin Powell, who gave me my last national security briefing:

"Mr. President," he said, "the world is quiet today."